

RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE: NATURE AND OBJECT

THREE-QUESTION METHOD → WILLIAM JAMES → RUDOLF OTTO AND THE → ADVAITA AND RADHAKRISHNAN → OBJECT MODELS → VERIDICALITY TESTS

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

00

STAGE 00THREE-QUESTION METHOD

THREE-QUESTION METHOD

RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE

1 PHENOMENOLOGY

WHAT IS IT LIKE?

2 OBJECT

WHAT IS EXPERIENCED — GOD, THE HOLY, BRAHMAN, EMPTINESS

3 EPISTEMIC FORCE

DOES SEEMING-TO-ENCOUNTER JUSTIFY BELIEF?

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE

1 PHENOMENOLOGY: what is it like?

2 OBJECT: what is experienced — God, the Holy, Brahman, emptiness, unity?

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

3 EPISTEMIC FORCE: does seeming-to-encounter justify belief?

TYPES: mystical unity

numinous encounter

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

prayer/worship revelatory vision

non-dual awareness

CONTROL: intensity and sincerity establish occurrence, not automatically veridical object.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious experience must be analysed through phenomenology, claimed object and epistemic force rather than treated as self-authenticating evidence.

01

STAGE 01WILLIAM JAMES

WILLIAM JAMES

JAMES'S MARKS OF MYSTICAL EXPERIENCE

CANNOT BE ADEQUATELY STATED

NOETIC QUALITY

FELT AS INSIGHT OR KNOWLEDGE

USUALLY BRIEF

RECEIVED RATHER THAN FULLY PRODUCED BY WILL

"FRUITS, NOT ROOTS"

JAMES'S MARKS OF MYSTICAL EXPERIENCE

INEFFABILITY: cannot be adequately stated

NOETIC QUALITY: felt as insight or knowledge

TRANSIENCY: usually brief

PASSIVITY: received rather than fully produced by will

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

JAMES'S MARKS OF MYSTICAL EXPERIENCE

INEFFABILITY: cannot be adequately stated

NOETIC QUALITY: felt as insight or knowledge

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

TRANSIENCY: usually brief

PASSIVITY: received rather than fully produced by will

"fruits, not roots": assess transformation in life, not only origin theory authority is strongest for experienter, not coercively

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

binding on outsiders plural experiences support openness, but diverse objects complicate doctrinal proof.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: James identifies recurrent marks of mystical experience and judges religion by enduring fruits without equating usefulness with truth.

02

STAGE 02RUDOLF OTTO AND THE NUMINOUS

RUDOLF OTTO AND THE NUMINOUS

THE NUMINOUS

MYSTERIUM TREMENDUM ET FASCINANS MYSTERIUM

WHOLLY OTHER, BEYOND ORDINARY GRASP TREMENDUM

AWE, MAJESTY, CREATURE-FEELING, DREAD FASCINANS

ATTRACTION, GRACE, COMPELLING VALUE

"HOLY" INCLUDES NON-RATIONAL NUMINOUS DEPTH PLUS MORAL/RATIONAL DEVELOPMENT

AUTOMATICALLY GOD

THE NUMINOUS = MYSTERIUM TREMENDUM ET FASCINANS

mysterium: wholly other, beyond ordinary grasp tremendum: awe

fascinans: attraction, grace, compelling value

"Holy" includes non-rational numinous depth plus moral/rational development

SACRED != automatically God: an object, place or event may mediate the Holy objection: description

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

THE NUMINOUS = MYSTERIUM TREMENDUM ET FASCINANS

mysterium: wholly other, beyond ordinary grasp tremendum: awe, majesty, creature-feeling, dread

fascinans: attraction, grace, compelling value

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

"Holy" includes non-rational numinous depth plus moral/rational development

SACRED != automatically God: an object, place or event may mediate the Holy objection: description can reify culturally

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

trained emotion into an external object.

THE NUMINOUS = MYSTERIUM TREMENDUM ET FASCINANS

mysterium: wholly other, beyond ordinary grasp tremendum: awe, majesty, creature-feeling, dread

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Otto's numinous is the non-rational encounter with the Holy as simultaneously overwhelming mystery and attraction.

03

STAGE 03ADVAITA AND RADHAKRISHNAN

ADVAITA AND RADHAKRISHNAN

APAROKṢĀNUBHŪTI IS IMMEDIATE KNOWLEDGE OF NON-DUAL BRAHMAN NOT SUBJECT

LIBERATING KNOWLEDGE

INTEGRAL INTUITION DISCLOSES SPIRITUAL UNITY AND GROUNDS TOLERANCE STRENGTH

EXPERIENCE IS TRANSFORMATIVE AND NON-INFERENTIAL PRESSURE

INEFFABILITY VS DOCTRINAL DESCRIPTION; PRIVATE CERTAINTY VS PUBLIC ADJUDICATION

ADVAITA INTERPRETATION MAY BE ONE CONCEPTUAL CONSTRUCTION AMONG RELIGIOUS

ADVAITA: aparokṣānubhūti is immediate knowledge of non-dual Brahman not subject seeing divine object

subject-object division is sublated śravaṇa → manana → nididhyāsana → liberating knowledge

RADHAKRISHNAN: integral intuition discloses spiritual unity and grounds tolerance strength: experience is transformative and non-inferential

private certainty vs public adjudication

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

ADVAITA: aparokṣānubhūti is immediate knowledge of non-dual Brahman not subject seeing divine object

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ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

RADHAKRISHNAN: integral intuition discloses spiritual unity and grounds tolerance strength: experience is transformative and non-inferential pressure: ineffability vs

private certainty vs public adjudication

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

Advaita interpretation may be one conceptual construction among religious traditions.

ADVAITA: aparokṣānubhūti is immediate knowledge of non-dual Brahman not subject seeing divine object

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Advaita interprets non-dual awareness as Brahman-realisation, while Radhakrishnan prioritises spiritual intuition over later doctrinal expression.

04

STAGE 04OBJECT MODELS

OBJECT MODELS

MODEL WHAT EXPERIENCE PRESENTS PERSONAL THEISM AN ADDRESSIVE "THOU."

OTTO NUMINOUS HOLY

WHOLLY OTHER

ADVAITA NON-DUAL BRAHMAN; NO FINAL SUBJECT-OBJECT SPLIT

BUDDHISM EMPTINESS, CESSATION OR SUCHNESS WITHOUT CREATOR NATURALISM ALTERED

SAME PHENOMENOLOGICAL REPORT MAY UNDERDETERMINE ONTOLOGY

OBJECT-CLAIM NEEDS INTERPRETATION BEYOND RAW IMMEDIACY.

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

MODEL WHAT EXPERIENCE PRESENTS personal theism an addressive "Thou," grace, command, presence

Otto numinous Holy / wholly other

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

Advaita non-dual Brahman; no final subject-object split

Buddhism emptiness, cessation or suchness without creator naturalism altered brain/body state interpreted religiously

EVALUATION / TRAP

SAME phenomenological report may underdetermine ontology

object-claim needs interpretation beyond raw immediacy.

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MODEL WHAT EXPERIENCE PRESENTS personal theism an addressive "Thou," grace, command, presence

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EVALUATION / TRAP

SAME phenomenological report may underdetermine ontology

object-claim needs interpretation beyond raw immediacy.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The sacred, the Holy, God and the Absolute are competing object-models, not interchangeable names for one uncontested referent.

05

STAGE 05VERIDICALITY TESTS

VERIDICALITY TESTS

SWINBURNE PRINCIPLE OF CREDULITY

ACCEPT SEEMING APPEARANCE UNLESS DEFEATED

PRINCIPLE OF TESTIMONY

GENERALLY TRUST REPORTS UNLESS THERE IS REASON NOT TO

PRIOR IMPLAUSIBILITY

UNRELIABLE SETTING POSITIVE CHECKS

MORAL FRUIT

SWINBURNE PRINCIPLE OF CREDULITY: accept seeming appearance unless defeated

PRINCIPLE OF TESTIMONY: generally trust reports unless there is reason not to

DEFEATERS: drugs/pathology

prior implausibility

unreliable setting positive checks: coherence

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

SWINBURNE PRINCIPLE OF CREDULITY: accept seeming appearance unless defeated

PRINCIPLE OF TESTIMONY: generally trust reports unless there is reason not to

DEFEATERS: drugs/pathology

prior implausibility

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

unreliable setting positive checks: coherence

moral fruit

intersubjective fit

predictive/explanatory value

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

ALSTON: socially established doxastic practice may confer prima facie justification objection: incompatible religious practices cannot all validate exclusive

objects unchanged.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Perception-like religious experience may have prima facie force, but diversity, pathology and counterevidence can function as defeaters.

06

STAGE 06CRITICISMS, REPLIES AND PUBLIC LIFE

CRITICISMS, REPLIES AND PUBLIC LIFE

SOCIAL CONSOLATION

NEURAL CORRELATE PLURALISM

CONTRADICTORY INTERPRETATIONS

NO COMMUNICABLE EVIDENCE REPLIES

CAUSAL EXPLANATION DOES NOT EQUAL DEBUNKING; ALL PERCEPTION HAS

FRUITS AND DISCIPLINED PRACTICES MAY DISTINGUISH MATURE EXPERIENCE FROM

PETITION, GRATITUDE, SURRENDER, CONTEMPLATION PUBLIC USE MUST BE MODEST

FREUD: wish-fulfilment

MARX: social consolation

neuroscience: neural correlate pluralism: contradictory interpretations

ineffability: no communicable evidence replies: causal explanation does not equal debunking; all perception has neural

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

FREUD: wish-fulfilment

MARX: social consolation

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

neuroscience: neural correlate pluralism: contradictory interpretations

ineffability: no communicable evidence replies: causal explanation does not equal debunking; all perception has neural correlates

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

fruits and disciplined practices may distinguish mature experience from fantasy prayer/worship test

object-relations: petition, gratitude, surrender, contemplation public

use must be modest: experience may justify commitment without authorising coercion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Prayer addresses the ultimate, worship enacts supreme worth, and public justification must translate private experience into shareable reasons.

07

STAGE 07PYQ ANSWER SPINE

PYQ ANSWER SPINE

DEFINE TYPE

DESCRIBE PHENOMENOLOGY WITH JAMES/OTTO

SPECIFY CLAIMED OBJECT

DISTINGUISH EXPERIENCE FROM INTERPRETATION

APPLY CREDULITY/TESTIMONY AND DEFEATERS

COMPARE ADVAITA/THEISM/BUDDHISM

STRONGEST NATURALIST OR PLURALIST OBJECTION

DEFINE type — describe phenomenology with James/Otto — specify claimed object

distinguish experience from interpretation — apply credulity/testimony and defeaters

compare Advaita/theism/Buddhism — strongest naturalist or pluralist objection

reply — qualified public verdict

CLOSE: religious experience is significant evidence within a life and practice, but its object is

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

DEFINE type — describe phenomenology with James/Otto — specify claimed object

distinguish experience from interpretation — apply credulity/testimony and defeaters

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

compare Advaita/theism/Buddhism — strongest naturalist or pluralist objection

reply — qualified public verdict

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

CLOSE: religious experience is significant evidence within a life and practice, but its object is not read straight off the feeling

interpretation and defeater control remain.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Public philosophical use of religious experience requires a distinction between sincere testimony, transformative fruit and metaphysical proof.

E

EXTRASUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

ADVANCED-DOSSIER RECONCILIATION — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

DOCTRINE STATEMENT:

MYSTICAL STATES ARE MARKED BY INEFFABILITY AND NOETIC QUALITY

THEIR AUTHORITY IS STRONGEST FOR THE SUBJECT AND TESTED

JAMES GATHERS FIRST-PERSON REPORTS, IDENTIFIES RECURRENT PHENOMENOLOGICAL FEATURES, AND

PRESUPPOSITION, CAUTION

FIRST-PERSON TESTIMONY IS LEGITIMATE DATA AND PRAGMATIC TRANSFORMATION IS

OPTIONAL SOURCE WITNESS

Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

Doctrine statement.

Mystical states are marked by ineffability and noetic quality, with transiency and passivity as usual additional marks

their authority is strongest for the subject and tested pragmatically by fruits.

ADVANCED OBJECTION

Argument.

James gathers first-person reports, identifies recurrent phenomenological features, and refuses to reduce their value to pathological origins because

Presupposition. CAUTION: First-person testimony is legitimate data and pragmatic transformation is evidentially relevant.

Distinction. Noetic quality means experienced insight, not independently demonstrated knowledge.

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

Canonical example. Conversion reorganises a divided self and is assessed through enduring moral integration.

Objection — reply.

CAUTION: Private certainty cannot establish a public object.

James restricts coercive authority; the experience may rationally authorise the experienter without binding outsiders.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.